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NEW CENTURY, NEW LIFE

Railway Board, Electrification and a Separate Budget

THE FIRST TWENTY-FIVE YEARS OF THE TWENTIETH CENTURY

The first twenty-five years of the twentieth century proved to be the most important ones for the railways in India. This was the time the railways were passing through a phase of consolidation and systematic improvements, with the government taking over control of small and scattered railway companies, putting a structure in place. In 1900, there were ninety-six different lines open to traffic, administered by thirty-three different companies. Between 1900 and 1914, when World War I broke out, the kilometre span of the Indian Railways increased from 39,833 km to 56,784 km, 1,210 km being added annually. [87]

By the turn of the century, India's railways were being consolidated, with a Railway Board taking shape for overall management of the network. In fact, the process had already begun in 1869, when the government introduced a policy of state construction and ownership, and since then, efforts were on to strengthen this aspect. By 1892, there was a Director General of Railways and by 1897, the post of Secretary to the Government of India in the Public Works Department was created.

BUYING OUT RAILWAY LINES